



A FREE GUIDE

# Help Me.

Why your body feels different after 35 — and how to  
actually fuel it.

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## FIRST, THE TRUTH

# It's not you.

You're doing the workouts. You're trying to eat well. You're pushing through the tired because that's what you do. And your body feels like it stopped cooperating somewhere around 38 or 40 — and just didn't tell you.

You're not imagining it. And you're not failing.

What's actually happening is perimenopause — and it starts much earlier than anyone ever told you.

Most women think perimenopause happens in their late 40s. The reality is it can begin as early as your mid-30s. The average woman starts noticing changes between 40 and 44 — a full decade before menopause itself. The symptoms are real, they're hormonal, and they have nothing to do with how hard you're trying.



“This isn't your body failing you. This is your body changing — and it needs a different approach, not more effort.”

# Sound Like Anything on This List?

*Check off what feels true right now.*

- ☐ Tired all the time — even when I sleep
- ☐ Workouts that used to work just don't anymore
- ☐ Weight sitting differently, especially around my middle
- ☐ Harder to recover between sessions
- ☐ Mood swings, anxiety, or just feeling off
- ☐ Motivation that comes and goes with zero warning
- ☐ Doing everything right and feeling like I'm getting nowhere

*These are not personal failures. They are physiological signals. Once you understand what's driving them, you can actually do something about it.*

# Your Hormones Shifted

During perimenopause, estrogen and progesterone don't crash — they fluctuate. Those fluctuations affect nearly everything.

## Sleep & Recovery



Progesterone is your calming hormone. As it fluctuates, sleep becomes lighter and harder to come by — even when you're exhausted.

## Muscle & Metabolism



Estrogen supports muscle protein synthesis. When it fluctuates, building and holding muscle gets harder — and less muscle means a slower metabolism.

## Cortisol & Stress



Lower estrogen makes you more sensitive to cortisol. High cortisol signals your body to store fat — especially around the middle — and makes recovery harder.

## Blood Sugar & Cravings



Estrogen helps regulate insulin sensitivity. As it fluctuates, blood sugar gets less stable — driving cravings, energy crashes, and mood swings.

“You don't need more discipline. You need a different strategy.”

# Three Shifts. Real Results.

You don't need to overhaul your life. You need a few specific changes that work with your hormones instead of against them.

1

## **Trade cardio hours for lifting sessions.**

Chronic cardio raises cortisol. Strength training 3–4 focused sessions a week builds the muscle that drives your metabolism and strengthens your bones.

2

## **Eat more protein, not less food.**

Under-eating raises cortisol and breaks down muscle. Protein at every meal stabilizes blood sugar, preserves lean tissue, and keeps you full. Most women in midlife eat about half the protein they need. This is where we're starting today.

**Let's start here.**

3

## **Treat recovery like it's part of the program.**

Sleep is where muscle rebuilds and cortisol resets. Because it is.

“Specific and intentional beats hard every single time.”

# Meal Planning & Smart Grocery Shopping



Pick 2–3 proteins, 2–3 carbs, and 3–4 veggies for the week. Mix and match to make different meals all week long — and hit that protein target from shift #2.

## Example:



**Proteins:** Chicken, ground turkey, salmon

**Carbs:** Quinoa, sweet potatoes, rice

**Veggies:** Spinach, bell peppers, zucchini

Make it yours — fill in your weekly picks:

My proteins this week:

My carbs this week:

My veggies this week:

# Sample Reset Meal Day

| MEAL                                                                                               | FOOD TO CHOOSE                                             | WHY THIS MATTERS                                             |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
|  <b>Breakfast</b> | Eggs + spinach + avocado on sourdough                      | <i>Protein + fat = keeps blood sugar stable</i>              |
|  <b>Lunch</b>     | Grilled chicken bowl with quinoa, roasted veggies + tahini | <i>Fiber + minerals to keep you full and energized</i>       |
|  <b>Dinner</b>    | Salmon + rice + greens sautéed in olive oil                | <i>Supports recovery and hormonal balance</i>                |
|  <b>Snacks</b>   | Greek yogurt + berries, or boiled eggs + hummus            | <i>Ditch the 3 p.m. crash without the shame snack spiral</i> |

Make it yours:

My favorite breakfast combo:

My go-to snack when I'm crunched for time:

*Still hungry after a meal? Increase your protein portion before reaching for more carbs or fat — it's the most satiating macro, and the easiest one to under-eat.*

# Portion Control, Using Your Hand

You don't need a food scale or a tracking app to eat well. Your hand is a surprisingly accurate and always-available portion guide — and it scales to your body because it's proportional to your size.



**FIST**

## **Vegetables & Carbohydrates**

1 serving of carbs or veggies — rice, potatoes, pasta, roasted vegetables



**PALM**

## **Protein**

1 serving of protein — chicken breast, fish fillet, ground meat



**THUMB**

## **Fats**

1 serving of fat — nut butter, oils, butter, cheese



**CUPPED HAND**

## **Snacks & Extras**

Nuts, seeds, dried fruit, granola — easy to overeat, use this as your guide

A balanced plate: 1 palm of protein + 1 fist of carbs + 1 fist of vegetables + 1 thumb of fat.  
Adjust based on hunger, energy, and training days.

# The Real Magic: Protein + Fiber

Protein and fiber both slow digestion and steady blood sugar — but paired together, they do a lot more than either does alone.

## PROTEIN ALONE

Keeps you full for  
2–3 hours

## FIBER ALONE

Keeps you full for  
4–6 hours



PROTEIN + FIBER = 8+ HOURS OF SATIETY

Good fiber sources to pair with your protein:



Beans, lentils & legumes



Oats & whole grains



Chia seeds & ground flax



Berries & apples (with skin)



Broccoli, brussels sprouts & leafy greens



Sweet potatoes & winter squash

# Quick Wins Checklist

- ☐ Ate 3+ balanced meals today
- ☐ Had protein at breakfast
- ☐ Didn't skip meals to "be good"
- ☐ Moved my body in a way that felt good — lifting counts
- ☐ Gave myself grace instead of guilt

Check 3+? You're already resetting.

Check 0? That's okay too — we just got started.

One small thing I'll do today:

# My Notes + Next Small Step

*This page is yours. Use it however helps.*

Which symptom from page 3 do I most want to address first?

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What's one meal or habit I want to repeat this week?

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Open notes:



## Ready for the Full Plan?

Strong, Not Sorry is the complete 8-week strength training guide built for exactly where you are — the direct next step from everything in this guide.

### STRONG, NOT SORRY

*The 8-Week Strength Plan for Women 35–55*

- ✓ Full 4-day training split with coaching cues
- ✓ 8-week progression system with a deload week
- ✓ Protein targets and nutrition basics
- ✓ Recovery protocol that actually works

**GET STRONG, NOT SORRY — \$27**

[femininestrengthco.com](https://femininestrengthco.com)

Want more than the plan — want a coach in your corner? I work 1:1 with women ready to rebuild strength, energy, and confidence for the long haul.

**DM me “COACH” to talk about 1:1 coaching**

You're not starting over.  
You're finally starting with the right information.

— Christin